

## Q How long will it take for my body to get back to normal?

Once you've had your baby, it's understandable that you want to feel like your old self again. It may, however, take several months for your body to return to normal so be patient and don't expect too much too soon.

### BODY CHANGES

Your body has been affected by growing and carrying your baby, so some physical changes are perfectly normal.

» **Breasts:** your breasts become swollen and hard, and may be sore as your milk comes in a few days after birth. This usually eases as breast-feeding becomes established.

» **Skin:** most women are left with some stretch marks. These are caused by the collagen beneath your skin tearing as it stretches to accommodate your growing baby. They may not go completely but they will fade with time.

» **Pelvic-floor muscles:** you may have temporary urinary incontinence, so find that a little bit of urine seeps out when you laugh, sneeze, or cough. Do Kegel exercises (see p.67) to strengthen the muscles.

There is no such thing as a **miracle cream** to get rid of stretch marks, but using moisturizer will keep your skin **smooth and supple**.

» **Hair:** due to changes in estrogen levels, it's normal to experience some hair loss for six to 12 months after the birth.

» **Abdomen:** your abdominal and pelvic muscles will be slack. If you had a vaginal delivery, you can do gentle abdominal exercises in the first few weeks. If you had a C-section, wait until after your six-week checkup.

» **Bladder:** the trauma on the bladder can put you at risk of a urinary-tract infection. Drink plenty of water to reduce the risk of this happening.

» **Anus:** many women develop hemorrhoids, (see p.132), in late pregnancy. Eat plenty of fiber and drink lots of water to ease bowel movements. Use an over-the-counter ointment on the affected area.



## Q I had stitches because I tore during the delivery. What can I do to ease the discomfort?

**It's normal to feel discomfort and soreness as this area heals and there are several ways to ease the discomfort.** Using analgesics will help you feel less pain. It can also help to apply towel-wrapped ice packs to your perineum, no longer than an hour at a time, in the first couple of days. Keep the perineum clean to avoid an infection, washing your hands before touching the area and bathing or showering regularly. Two or three drops of pure essential oils added to bath water can soothe perineal discomfort; lavender, geranium, and chamomile are recommended. Kegel exercises help blood flow to the perineal area, which promotes healing. Pouring a pitcher of warm water over your

vulva or using a water spray can be soothing and reduce the stinging sensation when you urinate. Urinating in a warm shower has the same effect. Squatting over rather than sitting on the toilet seat, or sitting with your feet and knees raised a little, can reduce stinging. Avoid getting constipated. Drink plenty of water and eat fiber-rich foods. If you had a bad tear or are constipated, you may be prescribed a mild laxative to soften your stools. Don't hold off going to the bathroom since it increases the risk of a UTI and constipation. Talk to your doctor if the area is still sore after a few weeks.

**As soon as you are able, get up and move around because activity can help with many things, including getting your digestive system working.**

## Q I'm exhausted and can hardly get out of bed. Is this normal?

**It's normal to feel exhausted in the early weeks and months.** Give your body time to heal. The hormone relaxin lingers in your body after the birth. In pregnancy, it makes your ligaments more elastic to deal with labor, but after the delivery, it can exacerbate complaints such as backaches and joint pain. If getting out of bed feels like an achievement, it is because it is! Sleeping when you can, eating well, and slowly becoming more active are key to recovery.